Coding standards are simply a set of rules that dictate how source code should be written. These standards are only concerned with how source code is presented; they do not enforce *what* you write but simply *how* you write. Coding standards will not prevent the creation of bad code, but they do ensure that bad code is at least easy to read. The best place to start with PHP coding standards is the PHP Framework Interop Group (PHP-FIG); their homepage can be found at https://php-fig.org/.

The PHP-FIG maintains a set of PHP Standards Recommendations – PSRs – that are concerned with how to write PHP itself and how to design common components for tasks such as logging, caching, event handling, and so on. The aim of this work is to ensure interoperability between PHP code maintained by different teams. The idea is that libraries, components, or entire frameworks are more easily integrated into projects if everything follows the same standards.

There are, of course, many other coding standards for PHP, but typically most are supersets of the PHP-FIG standards, so the PSRs are well worth learning (and enforcing; we'll see how to do that in a moment). Let's start with the Basic Coding Standard, PSR-1 (https://www.php-fig.org/psr/psr-1/).

PSR-1

The PSR-1 coding standard sets out some important fundamentals that all source code files must follow. This includes the encoding scheme for the files (UTF-8 without a byte-order mark – see Chapter 8, "Strings," if you're not sure what this means), the open/close tag style, what files are allowed to do (either declare symbols or cause effects – change in program state – but not both), and the conventions for names (classes, functions, constants). Perhaps most importantly, PSR-1 also enforces something called *autoloading*, which is a technique for loading new source code at runtime to find undeclared classes. Autoloading is covered in Chapter 6, "Object Fundamentals." Most importantly, where PSR-1 doesn't enforce standards, it does strongly recommend consistency.

If you only follow the PSR-1 standard, you will have code that will easily integrate with other code written to the same standard. Moving beyond PSR-1, there is the Extended Coding Style, PSR-12 (https://www.php-fig.org/psr/psr-12/).